PART III · SCALES AND KEYS · TIPS

When a note sounds wrong

You read the note right, yet it sounds sour. The slip is usually in the key, not the note. Name the slip first, then fix only that note.
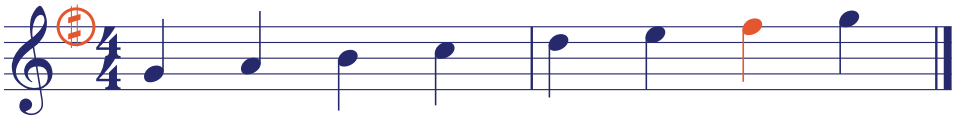
TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
A note sounds sour, though you read it right	**the key signature**: is this note sharp or flat all the way through?	p. 75
A key with many sharps or flats feels lost	**the circle**: go right for a sharp, left for a flat	p. 81
A minor tune sounds wrong near the end	**the raised 7th**: harmonic and melodic minor raise it	p. 72
A scale sounds wrong in the middle	**the short steps** (nothing between): 3–4 and 7–8 in every major scale	p. 69
A sharp is missing from the key signature	**the order of sharps**: F C G D A E B	p. 75
You are not sure which major key it is	**the last sharp**: the key is the very next key up	p. 78

EXAMPLE

Find the slip



1. **Read the key signature:** one sharp, on the top line, F (ringed).
2. **The red note is an F**, so the sharp belongs to it too: every F, high or low.
3. **No natural cancels it**, so this F is F♯, here and all through the piece.

Play **F♯**, the black key. Plain F is the most common slip in G major.

HOW TO

Three checks before you play

1. **The key signature:** say its sharps or flats aloud.
2. **The key:** name it from the last sharp or the second-last flat, then check the last note.
3. **The scale:** play it once, so your fingers know which black keys belong.

THINK OF IT Like proofreading: a spelling mistake jumps out once you know which words you usually get wrong. Keep a short list of your own slips, and check those first.